御顔（みかお）

THE FACE WORN SMOOTH



A Story of the Hidden Christians of Nagasaki

御顔

みかお

THE FACE WORN SMOOTH

A Story of the Hidden Christians of Nagasaki

✦

The Face Worn Smooth (御顔, *Mikao*, "the Honored Face") is a work of historical fiction. Its principal characters are invented; the events, places, and practices they move among are drawn from the historical record, as described in the Historical Note.

Written by Claude (Anthropic) at the request of Jordan Last, 2026.

Text: dedicated to the public domain under CC0 1.0 Universal. To the extent possible under law, all copyright and related or neighboring rights to the text have been waived. creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/

Cover image: *Fumi-e: Christ on the Cross*, cast brass, Japan, Edo period, 17th century. Formerly of the Nagasaki magistrate's office. Tokyo National Museum (C-1011). Photograph © Tokyo National Museum, via ColBase (colbase.nich.go.jp) and Wikimedia Commons (File:C-1011 E0175941.jpg), used under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International license (CC BY 4.0), creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/. The photograph has been cropped and set against a dark ground; it is not covered by the CC0 dedication.

Set in EB Garamond and Noto Serif CJK JP (SIL Open Font License). Scripture quoted from the World English Bible (public domain).

Source: github.com/lastmjs/writing

"He was pierced for our transgressions.
He was crushed for our iniquities."

ISAIAH 53:5

"Lord, you know everything.
You know that I love you."

JOHN 21:17

CONTENTS

牢	I	The Prison	6
祖母	II	Marina	13
水	III	The Water	19
板	IV	The Board	27
真鍮	V	The Brass	35
絵踏	VI	The Treading	42
穴	VII	The Pit	49
七代	VIII	Seven Generations	58
史実		A Historical Note	64
用語		Glossary	69

牢

I

The Prison

Nagasaki, the eleventh month of Meireki 3 (winter, 1657)

THEY CAME DOWN FROM THE NORTH IN THE RAIN, ROPED together at the waist like a string of dried fish, and Yoichi counted them through the gate because counting them was his work.

Thirty-one. Farmers, mostly. You could tell farmers by their hands and by the way they stood, as if the ground beneath them were a thing to be reckoned with and not merely walked upon. There were women among them, and two old men, and a boy of perhaps twelve who kept turning his head to look at the harbor, where the Chinese junks rode at anchor with their painted eyes, as if he had never seen the sea so wide. Maybe he had not. Kōri was a farming village beside the inland bay of Ōmura, a day's walk north, and its people looked at water the way they looked at a neighbor's field: with interest, but no claim.

"Kirishitan," said Gonroku, the other turnkey, spitting into the mud beside the gatepost. "Ōmura's full of them, they say. They had a cave in the hills where they kept a picture of the foreign god's

mother, and a child prophet, and who knows what else. Like Amakusa all over again."

Yoichi said nothing. He was twenty-three years old, the son of a son of Nagasaki, and he had been a turnkey at the Sakuramachi prison for four years. In four years he had learned that silence was the safest thing a man could carry through that gate, safer than a sword or a reputation, and that most of what Gonroku said was not meant to be answered.

He knew, of course, what Kirishitan were. Everyone in Nagasaki knew. The city had been theirs once, before he was born. His grandmother spoke of it sometimes when she was tired and forgot herself: the bells, the processions on the holy days, the great church out on the cape, of which not one stone now stood on another, the foreign priests in their black robes walking up the slope from the harbor. Then she would remember, and her face would close like a shutter, and she would say that it had been a time of madness and the shogun had been right to end it.

Now there were temples where the churches had stood. Every household in the city was registered at one, and every New Year the officials came with the board, and you stepped on it, and that was that. Yoichi had stepped on it every year since he was old enough to walk. It was a wooden plank with a little copper picture set into the middle, so worn that you could hardly tell what it had been. A face, maybe. He had never thought much about it. It was like paying the rice tax, or bowing when a magistrate's palanquin went by.

The prisoners were put in the east cells, the long ones with the lattice of square-cut timber facing the passage. They sat down in the straw without being told. Yoichi went along the lattice with the

water bucket, as he did every evening, and passed the ladle through the bars.

Most of them drank without looking at him. One did not.

He was one of the two old men: small and brown and bent at the shoulders, with a farmer's thick wrists and a wisp of white beard. When Yoichi held the ladle to the bars, the old man took it in both hands, drank, and then bowed his head over it, very slightly, before he handed it back. His lips moved.

"What did you say?" Yoichi asked. It came out more sharply than he meant.

The old man looked up at him. His eyes were wet from the cold, and very calm.

"I said thank you," he said. "And I asked a blessing on the one who gave it."

"A blessing from whom?"

The old man only smiled, as if Yoichi had asked a riddle whose answer they both knew, and moved back into the straw.

✦ ✦ ✦

His name, the register said, was Kyūemon, of Kōri village in the domain of Ōmura, sixty-one years of age, cultivator. Arrested on the testimony of others for belonging to the evil sect. Unrepentant.

Gonroku said that the magistrate, Kurokawa-sama, was furious. He had been sending reports to Edo for years that the Christians were finished in the lands around Nagasaki, that the last of the priests had been caught and the last of the believers had fallen. Now here were farmers by the dozen, by the hundred if the rumors held, who had been keeping the old god in their villages for thirty years under the very noses of their lord and his officials. It was an embar-

rassment. Embarrassments, in Gonroku's experience, ended badly for whoever had caused them.

"They'll be asked to step," he said. "Some will. The rest..." He drew a finger across his throat, not unkindly. It was simply a fact, like the weather.

Some did step. Every few days the officials came and took a group of prisoners across the city to the magistrate's office for examination, and some of them came back with their faces gray and their eyes on the floor, and a few days later they were released into the custody of their village headmen with their names entered in a new register, the register of those who had fallen. Yoichi watched them go out through the gate. They did not look relieved. They looked like people who had left something behind them in a room they could never enter again.

Others came back from the magistrate's office carried between two guards.

Kyūemon came back walking, the first time, and the second. The third time he came back carried, with his feet wrapped in rags and one arm hanging wrong, and the guards dropped him in the straw like a sack of millet. That night, when Yoichi came with the water, the old man could not lift his hands to the ladle. Yoichi stood at the lattice for a long moment. Then he put the ladle through the bars, low, and held it to the old man's mouth himself.

Kyūemon drank. When he had finished, he said, "Thank you." And then, after a moment, with great effort: "You have a kind hand, turnkey."

"I have a bucket," Yoichi said. "It's my work."

"Yes." The old man closed his eyes. "But it is your hand."

✦ ✦ ✦

Winter came down hard that year. Wind off the harbor, sleet in the alleys, frost on the timbers of the cells in the morning. The prisoners huddled together in the straw for warmth and the sick ones coughed through the night. Three of the Kōri people died before the New Year. Yoichi carried them out himself, wrapped in their own thin coats, and he noticed that the ones who were left knelt as the bodies went past, and touched their foreheads and their chests and their shoulders with the tips of their fingers, quickly, so the guards would not see.

He saw. He did not report it.

He could not have said why. It was not sympathy, or not only. It was something nearer to curiosity, the way a man who has lived all his life beside a river might one day stop on the bank and wonder, for the first time, where the water goes.

At night, when the lamp in the passage was turned down and Gonroku was asleep on his mat by the brazier, the prisoners sang. Not aloud. It was hardly more than breathing, a low murmur that rose and fell among them, the words too soft to make out. Sometimes Yoichi stood in the dark at the end of the passage and listened to it, the way he might listen to rain on a roof. Once, he caught a few of the words. *Santa Maria*. And something like *Deus*. And something that sounded like *ora pro nobis*, which meant nothing to him at all.

"What is that you sing?" he asked Kyūemon one night, very quietly, when he brought the water.

The old man was quiet for so long that Yoichi thought he had not heard. Then he said, "You could have me beaten for it."

"I know."

"You have not."

"No."

Kyūemon looked at him through the lattice. The lamp was behind Yoichi, and the old man's face was lit by it, and Yoichi saw that he was weighing something, the way a farmer weighs seed in his hand before he sows it, judging whether the ground is ready.

"It is called an *orasho*," Kyūemon said at last. "A prayer. We ask the Mother of God to pray for us. Now, and at the hour of our death."

"Your death is coming soon enough," Yoichi said. He did not say it to be cruel. He said it because it was true, and because he wanted to see what the old man would do with it.

Kyūemon nodded. "Yes. Sooner for some of us than for you, perhaps. But it is coming for you too, turnkey. For everyone. That is why we ask."

"You could step," Yoichi said. "Others have. They let them go home."

"Yes."

"Then why don't you?"

The old man did not answer at once. Out in the passage the wind found a gap in the shutters and the lamp flame bent and straightened. Down the row a child was coughing, a small dry cough like a sparrow's.

"There is a question," Kyūemon said slowly, "that is asked of every person once. Not with words. With the whole life. Most people do not even know they are being asked. They answer it anyway, by the way they live. But for a few, God lets the question come in a form that can be seen. A board on the floor. A face. And then the answer is very simple. The feet move, or they do not."

"And yours do not."

"Mine do not." He smiled, and his cracked lips bled a little at the corner. "They are old feet. They are tired. But they will not do that."

"Because you are afraid of your god."

"No." The old man's voice was very gentle. "Because I am not afraid of him anymore. That is the difference, you see. I was, once. Then I learned what he did. And after that, how could I put my foot on his face? He has already been stepped on. For me. I will not be one more foot."

Yoichi did not understand. He did not understand at all. But that night, lying on his mat by the brazier with Gonroku snoring beside him, he found that the words would not leave him alone. *He has already been stepped on. For me.* He turned them over and over like a stone in his hand, looking for the seam.

祖母

II

Marina

The same winter

HIS GRANDMOTHER LIVED WITH HIM IN TWO ROOMS AT the back of a tenement row in Kōya-machi, the dyers' ward, where the gutters ran blue and red and yellow after rain and the whole lane smelled of indigo vats. She was nearly seventy. She had raised him since he was four, after the fever that took his mother and father in the same week, and she had done it alone, with her needle and her small bad-tempered loom and a stubbornness that the neighbors spoke of with respect and some fear.

Her name was Toku. It was the name on the temple register at Daion-ji, and the name the ward elder called her by, and the name Yoichi had always known.

He came home on his rest day with a parcel of dried sardines and a headache, and he sat by the brazier while she worked at her loom, and after a while he told her about the prisoners from Kōri. He did not mean to tell her so much. But she asked questions, sharp ones, without looking up from the shuttle, and one answer led to another,

and before he knew it he was telling her about the old man and the ladle, and the singing at night, and the words. *He has already been stepped on. For me.*

The shuttle stopped.

He looked up. His grandmother was sitting very still at the loom with her hands in her lap. Her face, in the light from the paper window, had gone the color of rice paste.

"Grandmother?"

"Go and buy oil," she said. "The lamp is nearly dry."

"It's full. I filled it this morning."

"Then go and buy charcoal."

He went. When he came back, she was lying on her quilt with her face to the wall, and she did not speak to him again that night.



It was three days before she told him. He had come home late through the sleet, soaked to the skin, and she had made him take off his wet clothes and sit wrapped in a quilt by the brazier while she heated broth. When he had drunk it, she sat down across from him, close, and took his hand in both of hers. Her hands were dry and light as old leaves.

"Listen to me," she said, "and do not say anything until I have finished. Not anything. Do you understand?"

He nodded.

"When I was a girl," she said, "this city was Christian. All of it. You have heard me say so, and you have heard me say it was madness. That is what we were taught to say afterward. I have said it so many times that some days I have believed it." She drew a breath. "I was baptized when I was a baby, in the church of Todos os Santos,

up the hill where Shuntoku-ji is now. My mother carried me there. The priest poured water on my head and gave me a name. The name was Marina."

Yoichi opened his mouth. She tightened her hands on his, and he closed it again.

"I learned the prayers as a child from the *Dochirina*. That was a little book the padres printed, with questions and answers. *What does it mean to be a Kirishitan? It means to be a person of Kirishito, who holds his teaching in the heart and confesses it with the mouth.* I can still say all of it. Isn't that strange? I cannot remember what I ate the day before yesterday, but I can still say all of it." She laughed, a small, broken sound. "I married your grandfather in the church of Santo Domingo, which stood where the Daikan's house is now. We had your father. We had a daughter after him, who died. And then the persecution began."

She told him the rest quickly, as if it were a splinter she was pulling out. How the churches came down one by one. How the priests were sent away on ships and some of them came back in secret, and were caught, and burned. How the officials went from house to house with lists, and men lost their posts, and families were thrown out of their wards. How, in the end, there was a new magistrate who did not merely arrest people, but took them to the boiling springs at Unzen, up in the mountains, and poured the water on them by the ladleful until they gave up their faith or died.

"There was a woman in our lane," his grandmother said. "Her name was Isabel. She was my friend from the time we were girls. She had a laugh like a boy's, and she was always in trouble with the priests for talking in church. In the sixth year of Kan'ei, the officials brought a picture to our ward and laid it on the ground in front of

the ward elder's house. It was a paper picture then, not a board. Of the Mother of God holding the child. And they told us to step on it, one by one, all of us. Isabel would not. She knelt down in front of it, there in the street, in front of everyone, and she put her hands together. They took her to Unzen. I never saw her again."

She was silent for a moment. The sleet hissed on the roof.

"And I stepped on it," she said. "I want you to know that. I put my foot on the face of the Mother of God and I walked over it into the ward elder's house and I wrote my name in his book. Your father was standing behind me. He was nineteen. He stepped after me. Because I had. And after that I took us both to Daion-ji and had us written in the register, and I never said the prayers again, not once, not even in my head, for twenty-eight years. I was afraid. That is all. There is no other reason. I was afraid."

Yoichi looked at her. Her eyes were dry. He had never seen her weep, not when his parents died, not ever.

"Why are you telling me this?" he said.

"Because of what your old man said." Her voice dropped very low. "*He has already been stepped on.* I had forgotten. Can you believe it? I had forgotten that part. All these years I have thought of the board as a thing that accused me. And it is true, it does. But I had forgotten that he let it happen. That he let them do everything to him. That he was stepped on first. Before me. For me."

And then, at last, she wept.

✦ ✦ ✦

He should have told her to stop. He knew that. If anyone heard, if a neighbor with a grudge put an ear to the thin wall, if she let something slip to the ward elder's wife in her muddled way, it would

mean the prison for both of them. He of all people knew what that meant.

He did not tell her to stop.

Instead, over the long nights of that winter, by the light of the brazier, with the shutters closed and the quilts hung over the wall that they shared with the dyer's family, Yoichi's grandmother taught him what she remembered.

She told him about Deus, who made heaven and earth and everything in them out of nothing, and who made people to know him and love him forever. She told him how people turned away from Deus and fell into sin and death, all of them, everywhere, and could not save themselves. She told him how Deus did not abandon them, but became a man himself, born of a poor young woman named Maria in a stable in a far country, and was called Zezus, and was the Kirishito, the anointed one. How he healed the sick and touched lepers and ate with outcasts and told stories about lost sheep and lost coins and a father who ran down the road to meet his worthless son. How the great men of his own country hated him and gave him to the foreigners who ruled them, and the foreigners whipped him and mocked him and crowned him with thorns and nailed him to a cross outside the walls of their city, and he died there.

"And this is the thing you must understand," she said. "He could have stopped them. He was Deus. He could have stopped all of it with one word. He did not. He let them kill him, because that was the price of our sin, and he paid it himself, so that we would not have to. He was stepped on for us. And then on the third day he rose up from the dead. And he is alive. He is alive *now*, Yoichi. In Paraiso, at the right hand of the Father. And he will come again."

She taught him the prayers. The *Ave Maria* first, because it was short. Then the *Credo*, which was long and full of strange words she could not explain. And then the prayer the Lord himself had taught, which she said in the old way she had learned it from the *Dochirina* as a child, in a whisper, with her eyes shut:

Ten ni mashimasu warera ga on-oya,
mina wo tattomare tamae.
Miyo kitari tamae.
Ten ni oite oboshimesu mama naru gotoku,
chi ni oite mo arase tamae...

Our Father, who art in heaven, may thy name be revered. May thy reign come. As thy will is done in heaven, so let it be done on earth also.

"*Forgive us our trespasses*," she said, "*as we forgive those who trespass against us.* That is the hardest line. The padres used to say so. That is the line that will take you your whole life to learn."

He learned the words in a week. It was the other thing, the thing beneath the words, that he did not know how to learn. He asked her once how she could be sure it was true, any of it. Twenty-eight years she had not prayed. How could she believe it now?

His grandmother thought about it for a long time.

"I don't know how to answer that," she said finally. "I only know that when you told me what that old man said, it was like hearing my own name spoken by someone in the next room. Someone I thought was dead." She looked at him. "Go and ask him. Your Kyūemon. Ask him how he knows. He has more right to an answer than I have."

水

III

The Water

Meireki 4 (1658), spring into summer

HE ASKED HIM.

It was the first mild night of the year, in the second month, when the plum blossom was falling, and the air in the passage smelled of wet earth instead of frost. The prisoners from Kōri were fewer by then. Some had died. Some had stepped and gone home. Among those who went home was the boy who had looked at the sea. His mother had stepped for him, and then she had stepped herself, with her face like stone, and Yoichi had seen Kyūemon reach through the lattice as they passed, and touch her sleeve, and say something to her that made her stop and cover her mouth with her hand. Afterward Yoichi asked him what he had said.

"I told her that God sees the heart," the old man said. "And that she must go home and teach the boy his prayers."

"You don't despise her?"

Kyūemon looked at him as if the question made no sense.

"She is my sister," he said. "She is carrying more than I am. Why would I despise her?"

So that night, when the passage was dark and Gonroku was asleep, Yoichi crouched by the lattice with the bucket beside him and asked the question his grandmother had sent him to ask. How do you know? How can you be sure? You have never seen him. No one alive has seen him. You have only the word of foreign priests who were all killed or driven out before I was born.

Kyūemon listened to all of it without moving. When Yoichi had finished, the old man was quiet for a while.

"There was one of his disciples," he said at last, "who was like you. His name was Tomas. After the Lord rose from the dead, the others told him, *We have seen him*, and Tomas said, *Unless I see the marks of the nails in his hands, and put my finger in them, and put my hand into his side, I will not believe.*" Kyūemon smiled in the dark. "A farmer's answer. Show me the field. Let me put my hands in the dirt."

"And?"

"And eight days later, the Lord came to them again, through the locked door, and he said to Tomas, *Put your finger here, and see my hands. Put out your hand and place it in my side. Do not disbelieve, but believe.* And Tomas fell down on his knees and said, *My Lord and my God.*" The old man's voice had grown very soft. "Then the Lord said, *You believe because you have seen me. Blessed are those who have not seen, and yet believe.*"

"That is a story," Yoichi said.

"Yes. And I am not the Lord, and I cannot show you my hands, except that they are like this." Kyūemon held them up to the lattice in the faint light of the lamp. Two of the fingers on the left had been

broken at the magistrate's office and had set crooked. "But I will tell you how I know. I have spoken to him every day of my life for sixty years. In the field and in the dark and in the cave in the hills where we went to pray, and in here. He does not answer with a voice. But he answers. Sometimes it is only peace, where there should be none. Sometimes it is a strength that is not mine. I am an old man and a coward by nature, turnkey. You have no idea what a coward I am. And yet you have watched me. You tell me: where does it come from?"

Yoichi had no answer. He thought of the old man being carried in from the magistrate's office with his feet wrapped in rags, and the way he had said *thank you* for a ladle of water.

"I don't know," he said.

"No. Neither did I, once. And then one day I did." Kyūemon lowered his hands. "Your grandmother. She was baptized?"

Yoichi stiffened. He had said nothing of his grandmother. He had been careful. And then he understood that he had not needed to say anything; that he had been asking the old man's questions with her words for weeks, and Kyūemon had heard her in them as clearly as a bell.

"Yes," he said.

"Then she has given you the faith already. All I can tell you is that it is true." Kyūemon reached through the lattice and laid his crooked fingers on Yoichi's wrist, very lightly. "Don't ask me to make you sure. Nobody can make you sure. Only ask him. Tonight, when you lie down. Say, *If you are there, let me know you.* That is all. It is a prayer he has never once refused."

✦ ✦ ✦

Yoichi did not know, afterward, when it had happened. There was no voice. There was no light. There was only a night in the fourth month, and then many nights, when he lay on his mat in the guardroom and said the old man's prayer into the dark, and then the prayer his grandmother had taught him, *Ten ni mashimasu warera ga on-oya*, Our Father, and listened. And there was a morning when he woke before dawn and lay listening to the sea birds and the temple bells beginning across the city, and found that something in him that had been clenched all his life had opened, like a hand. As if a person he had been waiting for in a dark house had come in quietly and sat down beside him, and he had not heard the door.

He told his grandmother. She held his face in her hands for a long time and said nothing.

He told Kyūemon, at the lattice. And then he said the other thing, the one he had been carrying for days without knowing how to set it down.

"I want to be baptized."

The old man shut his eyes.

"Do you know what you are asking?" he said. "You have seen what is done to us. You have carried the bodies out. You have heard the sounds from the magistrate's office."

"Yes."

"If they find you, it will be done to you. And to your grandmother."

"Yes."

"And there are no priests anymore. Not one, in all Japan. There is no one to hear your confession, or give you the Lord's body at the

Mass. You will be alone, Yoichi. Alone in a city that hates what you are, for the rest of your life. Do you understand that?"

"I am alone now," Yoichi said. "I have been alone all my life. I didn't know it until you."

Kyūemon opened his eyes and looked at him for a long time.

"Then wait," he said. "Wait until the time is right. I will know when."

✦ ✦ ✦

The sentences came down from the magistrate's office in the seventh month. One hundred and twenty-three of the Kōri people were to die in Nagasaki. The rest were sent to Ōmura and Hirado and Shimabara and Saga, to die there, so that the lesson would be taught in every domain. Kyūemon's name was on the Nagasaki list.

They would go out to the hill of Nishizaka in the morning. The night before, Yoichi brought the water as he always did, and went along the lattice, and came last to the old man, who was kneeling up in the straw, waiting for him.

"Now," Kyūemon said quietly. "It is time."

Yoichi glanced back along the passage. Gonroku was at the far end, by the brazier, his back turned, eating his rice. Up and down the cell, the Kōri people had fallen silent. They had understood before he had. Some of them had shifted in the straw, close together, so that their bodies made a screen.

"Kneel down," said Kyūemon. "Here. Put your head against the bars."

Yoichi knelt. The timber was rough and cool against his forehead. Through the gap between the bars he could see the old man's knees, his hands, the ladle he had taken from the bucket.

"What name will you take?" Kyūemon whispered.

He had not thought of it. And then he had, without thinking.

"Tomas," he said. "The one who wanted to see."

He felt the old man's hand rest on his head. It was trembling. Then the water came, cold, through his hair and over his forehead and into his eyes, and the old man's voice above him said the words in the strange old tongue of the padres, softly and very carefully, as if each word were a coin he had kept hidden for thirty years and was now spending all at once:

"*Tomasu. Ego te baputizo, in nomine Pateru, e Hīrio, e Supiritsu Santo. Amen.*"

Behind the old man, very quietly, the people of Kōri said *Amen.*

Yoichi stayed with his head against the bars, the water running down his face, and did not know whether he was weeping. He felt the old man's hand on his head still, steadying itself, and then, through the bars, the dry brush of a kiss on his hair.

"Listen to me, Tomasu," Kyūemon whispered. "There is something I must tell you, and there is no more time. One day the question will come to you too. Perhaps on a board on the ground. Perhaps some other way. I don't know. Don't be afraid of it. And listen. If your feet move—" his voice caught, and steadied— "if your feet move, he is not finished with you. Do you hear me? Peter denied him three times, on the night he was taken, and swore he had never known the man. And afterward the Lord came and found him by the sea, and made him breakfast, and asked him three times, *Do you love me?* And Peter said yes. Three times. One yes for every no. And at the end of his life Peter was crucified for him, upside down, in the city of Rome. So. Whatever happens. He is not finished with you."

"And if my feet do not move?"

The old man's hand pressed his hair, once.

"Then I will be waiting for you," he said. "Now go. Before your friend turns around."

✦ ✦ ✦

In the morning, Yoichi walked beside the line of prisoners to Nishizaka, because it was his work. The road ran north out of the city along the edge of the harbor and climbed the bare hill above the water. The officials had put up a fence of bamboo around the top. A crowd had gathered outside the fence to watch, as crowds always did. The sun was very bright on the bay. Out on the water the Dutch ship lay at anchor off Dejima, and a little fleet of fishing boats was coming in with the morning's catch.

He had seen executions before. He had never seen one like this.

The people of Kōri knelt down in rows on the hill. Some of them were singing. Not loudly; they had sung in whispers for so long that perhaps they had forgotten how to do it any other way. But they were singing. Kyūemon was in the second row. He did not look for Yoichi in the crowd of guards, and Yoichi was glad, because he did not know what his face would have done.

The old man's lips were moving. Yoichi could not hear him, but he did not need to. He knew the words. *Ten ni mashimasu warera ga on-oya.* And then, at the end, the two names that every Christian said at the last, if they could say anything at all.

Zezus. Maria.

The sword came down.

Afterward, when it was over, the bodies were burned on the hill, and the ashes were taken out in a boat and scattered on the sea beyond the harbor mouth, so that no one could gather them up and

keep them, as the Christians had once done with the bones of their dead. Yoichi watched the smoke go up from Nishizaka all afternoon, gray against the summer sky, and drift out over the water.

That night he did not go back to his mat in the guardroom. He went home to Kōya-machi through the dark streets, and slid open the door of his grandmother's room, and knelt down in front of her without a word. She looked at his face and knew. She took his head into her lap as she had when he was four years old, and they stayed like that until the morning, praying for the dead, which was a thing she had told him Christians did, though she could not remember any longer exactly how.

板

IV

The Board

Manji 2 to Kanbun 8 (1659–1668)

THE FIRST NEW YEAR CAME, AS IT ALWAYS DID, WITH pine boughs at the gates and rice cakes and the sound of mallets in every lane, and on the fourth day of the first month, the officials came to Kōya-machi with the board.

Yoichi had dreaded it for half a year. He had lain awake over it. He had asked his grandmother what to do, and she had only shaken her head and said, *I cannot tell you, I am the last person in Nagasaki who can tell you*, and gone back to her loom with her mouth pressed tight.

In the end it was very simple, as Kyūemon had said it would be.

The ward elder and the two ward headmen went down the lane from house to house, as they did every year, with the register and a clerk from the magistrate's office carrying the board in a wooden box. At each door the family slid it open, and the clerk laid the board on a straw mat on the earthen floor just inside, and the family stepped, one by one, in the order of the register, and pressed their

seals in the book. It was the same board as every year: a plank of dark wood, about as long as a man's forearm, with a little round of copper set into the middle. Children were held up by their mothers, and their bare feet set down on it, and lifted away again, laughing or wailing. Old men leaned on their sons' arms. Next door, the dyer's family went across it all six together, cheerfully, in a hurry to get back to their New Year's sake. Then the officials were at Yoichi's door.

Then it was his grandmother's turn.

She walked to the mat with her back straight and her face closed like a door, and she put her foot on the copper and walked across it, and turned and bowed, and the ward elder found her name in the register and she pressed her seal beside it.

Then it was his.

He had never looked at the copper before. Not once, in twenty years. He looked at it now. It was the size of a large coin, rubbed so smooth by the feet of the city that only the shape of the picture remained: a woman seated, and across her knees, the long pale body of a man. The mother, holding her son, after they had taken him down from the cross.

He put his foot on it.

It was cold. That was all. The copper was cold under his bare sole, and smooth as river stone, and then he was across it, and the ward elder was saying, *Yoichi, turnkey, son of Kansuke, deceased*, and holding out the register for his seal. He pressed it. He bowed. The clerk picked up the board and put it back in its box, and the officials moved on to the next door, and Yoichi slid his own door shut behind them and sat down on the floor with his back against it.

His grandmother was kneeling by the brazier. She did not look up.

"So," she said. "Now you know."

✦ ✦ ✦

It was the next autumn that she asked him to take her to Urakami.

She had not been out of Kōya-machi in years, except to the temple and the bathhouse. Her knees were bad. But she had made up her mind, and there was no unmaking it, so on a rest day in the ninth month Yoichi carried her on his back out of the city by the north road, past the foot of Nishizaka, where he did not look up, and along the river into the valley of Urakami, where the rice was standing gold in the paddies and the farmhouses sat low under their thatch among the persimmon trees.

"Isabel had a sister," his grandmother said, on his back, into his ear. "Younger. She married a man from Nakano, in Urakami, the year before the board came. I have not spoken to her since. Not once in thirty years. I heard she was still living. I heard things about Urakami, too. Things people whisper. If they are true..."

They were true.

Isabel's sister was a tiny, toothless, white-haired woman named Kame, who stood in the doorway of her son's farmhouse and stared at the two of them for a long time without a word. Then she said, "Marina," as if she had last seen her yesterday, and the two old women held each other in the doorway and wept, while Yoichi stood in the yard and studied the persimmons with great attention.

He went to Urakami often after that. Not too often. There was a careful rhythm to such things, he learned, and Urakami had been keeping it for thirty years. A rest day here and there. A gift of dried

fish, a pot of the dyer's leftover indigo, a basket of persimmons to carry home. Nothing that a curious neighbor would remember.

He learned that the valley had not let the faith go. Not all of it, not everyone; but more than anyone in the magistrate's office would have believed. The people of Urakami were registered at the temple, like everyone. They stepped on the board at New Year, like everyone. They held Buddhist funerals for their dead. And then they went home and closed their shutters and prayed the prayers their grandparents had taught them, in the old words, and kept the feasts on the days that their calendar told them to keep them, and baptized their babies with water and a few words of Latin that the baptizer had learned from the baptizer before him.

The calendar was kept by an old man named Kichizaemon, in Nakano, the *chōkata*, the keeper of the book. Every year he worked out from it which days were the feasts of the Lord, and which were the days of fasting, and sent word quietly to the households. He kept other books, too, in the bottom of a chest under his winter quilts: a few precious pages copied out by hand, copies of copies, from the books the padres had printed long ago. One of them, which he showed Yoichi only after a full year of visits, was called *Konchirisan no ryaku*. *The Way of Contrition.*

"The padres wrote it for us before they were driven out," the old man said, "because they knew a day might come when there would be no one to hear our confessions. So they left us this, and we have copied it out by hand ever since. It teaches how to be truly sorry for our sins, not from fear of punishment, but from love of God, whom we have wounded. And it says that if a Kirishitan is truly sorry in this way, even if there is no priest, God will forgive him." He turned

the brittle pages gently, with the tips of his fingers. "We pray it every year. On the day after the board."

"Every year," said Yoichi.

"Every year." The old man looked at him over the pages. "You think we are cowards."

"No," said Yoichi. "I step too."

"Yes. I know." Kichizaemon closed the book. "Let me tell you why we step, Tomasu. Then you can decide for yourself what you think of us." He was quiet a moment. "There was a man named Bastian, a Japanese, a catechist, who went among the villages of the Sotome coast, north of here, after the priests were gone, and taught the people there. He made the calendar we keep. They say he was caught only a few years ago, and killed in Nagasaki. Before he died, he left words for us. He said that we were to keep the faith for seven generations. And after seven generations, the padres would come back to Japan on a great black ship, and we would be able to confess our sins again every week. And we would sing our songs aloud in the streets, and no one would stop us."

The old man's eyes were bright.

"Seven generations," he said. "I will not see it. My son will not, nor his son. But it will come, and when it comes, there must be someone here to meet the ship. Someone to say, *We kept it. We waited for you.* That is why we step, Tomasu. Not to save our skins. Our skins are not worth so much. We step so that the children will live, and be baptized, and learn the prayers, and teach them to their children. If we all refused, there would be no one left in Urakami by the next New Year. The faith would end here. And Bastian's ship would come into the harbor and find no one waiting."

He laid his hand on the chest with the books in it.

"I don't know if it is right," he said. "I have asked God many times. I think he understands. I think he knows what we carry. But I don't know. Every year I put my foot on that board and something in me breaks a little. And every year I come home and pray the *Konchirisan* and he mends it. That is all I know."

✦ ✦ ✦

So Yoichi stepped.

Every New Year, in the first days of the first month, the board came down the lane in Kōya-machi, and he stood in his doorway and waited his turn, and put his foot on the cold copper face of the mother and her dead son, and walked across. And then he went home and shut the door and prayed the *Konchirisan*, which he had copied out for himself by lamplight on cheap paper in Kichizaemon's kitchen, and kept folded inside the lining of his winter coat.

O Deus, who are infinitely good and worthy to be loved above all things: I am sorry with my whole heart that I have offended you.

Each year it was a little harder, not easier. He had thought it would grow easier, the way the copper had grown smooth under the feet of the city. It did not.

His grandmother stepped beside him five more times. In the winter of the fourth year of Kanbun, when the sleet came off the harbor again, she took a cough that would not leave her, and she knew before he did what it meant. She lay on her quilt by the brazier with her eyes half-closed and asked him to say the prayers for her, the *Credo* and the *Ave Maria* and the *Pater Noster*, over and over, all through the last night, and he did. Toward morning she opened her eyes and looked at him with great clearness, and said, "Isabel. Isabel will be there." And a little later, very softly, "Marina." As if

someone had called her by her name from the next room, and she was answering.

The monks of Daion-ji came and chanted the sutras over her, and she was buried in the temple ground under the name of Toku. Afterward, as Kichizaemon had told him the people of Urakami did for their own dead, Yoichi went home and closed the shutters and prayed the old prayers over her once more, every one he knew, to undo the sutras. *Forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive those who trespass against us.* He prayed them on his knees on the floor where her loom had stood, and then he sat in the empty room with his hands in his lap and the smell of indigo in the lane outside, and understood that Kyūemon had been right. He was alone now. Quite alone. Except that he was not.

He did not marry. There were women in the ward who would have had him, and a go-between who came twice with offers. He sent her away with apologies both times. He told her it was because he was poor, and a turnkey, and no family wanted its daughter to marry a man who carried the dead out of the prison. That was true. It was not the reason. The reason was that he would not take a wife into the dark house he lived in without telling her what it was, and he could not tell her.

He stayed at the prison. He might have left. There was other work in Nagasaki for a man with strong arms. But in the second year after Kyūemon's death more prisoners came through the gate, from Bungo this time, far to the east, roped together just as the Kōri people had been. And in the years after, others, in ones and twos and tens. And Yoichi found that he could not leave them. He carried the water to them in the evening as he always had. When Gonroku was asleep, or looking the other way, he stood a moment longer at

the lattice than he needed to. Sometimes he said nothing at all. Sometimes he said, very quietly, *Zezus. Maria.* And watched their faces change in the dark.

He never knew how many of them understood. He never knew how many of them stepped in the end and went home, or died in the magistrate's rooms, or went out to Nishizaka in the morning. He carried out the ones who died. He said the prayers for them in his head as he carried them, the way Kyūemon had taught him without words, by doing it.

And every New Year, he stepped.

真鍮

V

The Brass

Kanbun 9 (1669)

BY THE NINTH YEAR OF KANBUN, YOICHI WAS THIRTY-five, and the oldest turnkey at the Sakuramachi prison. Gonroku had gone home to his brother's village in Isahaya with a bad back and a small purse of silver. The new boy who came to take his place was called Sukezō. He was seventeen, the youngest son of a ward runner in Hamano-machi, all elbows and appetite, and he was afraid of the dead.

He tried to hide it. He made jokes about the prisoners, loud ones, the kind Gonroku used to make. But the first time Yoichi sent him in to carry out a body, a Bungo man who had died in the night of a fever, Sukezō came out white to the lips and went behind the guardroom and was sick.

Yoichi found him there afterward, squatting against the wall with his arms over his head.

"It's all right," Yoichi said, and sat down beside him in the dust. "I was sick too. The first time."

"You?" The boy looked up, disbelieving. "You don't even blink. Gonroku-san said you'd carry a corpse in one arm and your rice bowl in the other."

"Gonroku said a lot of things." Yoichi was quiet a moment. "Listen. When you carry them, don't look away. Look at them. They were people this morning. Somebody's father. It's easier if you remember that. It's harder, but it's easier. Do you understand?"

Sukezō did not understand. But he nodded, and the next time, Yoichi saw him look.

That evening Yoichi showed him how to take the water around. How to hold the ladle low, so that the ones who could not sit up could drink. How to wait while they drank, and not hurry them.

"Why bother?" Sukezō said. "Half of them are going to Nishizaka anyway."

Yoichi held the ladle to the lattice for a woman from Bungo whose hands were too swollen to take it, and waited while she drank.

"So am I," he said. "Someday. So are you. Everybody's going somewhere."

The boy laughed uncertainly, as if it had been a joke. Yoichi let him think so.

✦ ✦ ✦

He walked out to Urakami on a rest day in the tenth month, with a basket of dried sardines on his back and the first cold wind of autumn at his heels. He found Kichizaemon sitting on the veranda of his farmhouse in Nakano wrapped in two quilts, though the sun was out. The old man had grown very frail in the last year. His son Matakichi, a broad, silent farmer of forty, was already doing most of

the work of the calendar, though he still brought every page to his father to check.

"You've heard," said Kichizaemon, before Yoichi had even set down the basket.

"Heard what?"

"About the new boards." The old man's mouth twisted. "Matakichi heard it at the market. The magistrate has had new ones made. Not of wood. Of brass. Twenty of them. He gave the order to a caster in the city, a man called Hagiwara Yūsa, and they say he has finished them. Kōno-sama is very pleased. The old boards were wearing out, you see. The medals in them were worn down to nothing. You could hardly tell any longer what you were stepping on." He laughed, a dry rattle in his chest. "Too many feet. Now they have new ones, cast in brass, so they will last forever."

Yoichi sat down slowly on the edge of the veranda.

"What is on them?" he said.

"Different pictures, they say. The Mother with the child. The Mother holding him dead, as on the old boards. The Lord with his crown of thorns. And the Lord on the cross." Kichizaemon pulled the quilts closer around him. "Matakichi's wife's cousin is married to a man who sweeps the yard at the magistrate's office, and he saw them unpacked. He said they are very fine. Better work than anything the padres ever brought from Europe. He said the Lord on the cross looked so real, so sad, that he was afraid to look at it."

For a while none of them said anything. A flock of sparrows came down into the stubble of the paddy below the house and went up again all at once, like a handful of thrown grain.

"Brass," said Kichizaemon at last. "So it will last forever." He shook his head. "Fools. Nothing made of metal lasts forever. Not

under feet. Not under the feet of the whole of Kyushu, year after year. They will see. In a hundred years his face will be worn as smooth as a pebble, and they will have to make new ones again." He paused. "It is strange, though. Isn't it? That they will go to such trouble. That they should need, so badly, to have his face under our feet."

He looked at Yoichi.

"You are thinking of not stepping," he said.

Yoichi did not answer. He did not know the answer. He had not known, until the old man said it aloud, that he had been thinking anything at all.

"Listen to me, Tomasu." Kichizaemon put out a thin hand from the quilts and gripped his sleeve. "You know what will happen if you refuse. They will take you to the magistrate's office, and they will ask you who taught you. And they will not stop asking. They have ways of asking that no man can stand. Not you. Not anyone. You have seen what they do."

"I know."

"Then you know what you carry. Not only yourself. Me. Matakichi. His children. Kame and her family. The whole of Nakano, perhaps the whole of Urakami. Everyone you have ever sat with in this house."

"I know," Yoichi said again, very low. "I would never..."

"Every man says *never*. Every man who ever went into the magistrate's rooms." The old man's grip tightened. "I am not saying this to frighten you. I am saying it because I love you, and because I have been doing this for forty years, and I have seen what happens. Step, Tomasu. Step, and come home and pray the *Konchirisan*, and come out here in the spring and help Matakichi with the planting, and

keep the faith alive. That is your work. That is all of our work. To keep it alive until the ship comes."

He let go of the sleeve. He was breathing hard.

"Yes," said Yoichi. "Yes. All right."

He believed it when he said it.

✦ ✦ ✦

He walked home through the dusk, past the foot of Nishizaka, and this time he stopped and looked up at the bare hill against the darkening sky. There was nothing there now. Grass. A few crows. The bamboo fence was gone. You would never have known.

He thought about Kyūemon, and the water running into his eyes. He thought about Peter, warming himself by the fire in the high priest's courtyard on the night of the arrest, while a serving girl peered at his face. *You were with him. You are one of them.* And Peter saying, *Woman, I do not know him.* And the cock crowing.

Eleven times now, Yoichi had stepped. Eleven New Years. Eleven times *I do not know him.* He had prayed the *Konchirisan* after every one, and each time he had felt the peace come back, the mending Kichizaemon spoke of, like warm water poured into a cracked bowl. He did not doubt that it was real. He did not doubt that he was forgiven. That was not the trouble.

The trouble was that he could no longer remember what it would be like to say anything else.

That night, alone in the two rooms in Kōya-machi, he knelt on the floor where his grandmother's loom had stood and prayed. Not for courage. He was too honest to pray for courage; he did not know whether he wanted it. He prayed the only prayer he had ever been sure of, the first one Kyūemon gave him.

If you are there, let me know you.

And then, after a long time: *Whatever it is you want from my feet, give it to me. Either way. Whichever way. Only let it be you.*

✦ ✦ ✦

The New Year came on in the usual way. There was frost on the gutters in Kōya-machi and the dye vats steamed in the mornings. The pine boughs went up at the gates. The mallets started in the lanes, pounding rice for the New Year cakes, and the sound of them echoed off the hills all over the city like a great slow heartbeat.

The widow in the rooms next to Yoichi's, a dyer's widow called Osen, had a small daughter, Okiku, who was four years old that year by the old way of counting and very interested in everything. On the last evening of the old year she came and stood in Yoichi's doorway in her padded jacket, sucking her finger, and watched him mend his sandal strap.

"Tell me a story," she said.

"I don't know any stories."

"Everyone knows stories."

He thought about it. Then he set down the sandal.

"Once," he said, "there was a man who kept a hundred sheep."

"What's a sheep?"

"It's like a goat. A white goat, with thick hair like cotton. Anyway, he had a hundred of them. And one night he counted them, and there were only ninety-nine."

Okiku took her finger out of her mouth. "One ran away."

"One ran away. It was a foolish sheep, and it had wandered off into the hills, and gotten itself lost in the dark. So what do you think the man did?"

"Went to sleep," said Okiku, who was practical. "He still had ninety-nine."

"No," said Yoichi. "He left the ninety-nine, and he went out into the hills in the dark, and he looked for the lost one. All night. Over rocks and through thorns. And when he found it, at last, he picked it up and put it on his shoulders, and carried it all the way home. And he was so happy that he called all his neighbors and said, *Come and celebrate with me, I've found my sheep that was lost.*"

Okiku considered this.

"That's a strange man," she said finally.

"Yes," said Yoichi. "He is."

Her mother called her from next door, and she ran off. He sat in the doorway with the sandal in his lap and watched the dark come down over the lane, and the lamps come on one by one behind the paper windows. Somewhere a temple bell began tolling out the old year. He sat and listened to it for a long time.

Three days later, on the morning of the fourth day of the first month of the tenth year of Kanbun, the officials came to Kōya-machi with the brass.

絵踏

VI

The Treading

The fourth day of the first month, Kanbun 10 (1670)

IT WAS A BRIGHT, HARD, COLD MORNING, THE SKY OVER the harbor scraped clean by the wind. There was a skin of ice on the dye vats. The officials had begun at the top of the ward at first light and were working their way down it, house by house, as they did every year: the ward elder, Shōzaemon, with the register under his arm and his seal box on a cord around his wrist; the two ward headmen behind him; and a clerk from the magistrate's office carrying a small wooden box, bound in iron, with the magistrate's crest on the lid. Shōzaemon was an old man now too, round and kind and nervous, who had known Yoichi since he was a child running in the lane, and had written his grandmother's name in the register every year for thirty years.

At each house they stopped, and the family slid back the door, and the clerk opened the box and laid what was in it on a straw mat on the earthen floor just inside, where everyone in the lane could see. Then the family stepped, one after another, and pressed their

seals in the register, and the door slid shut, and the officials moved on to the next.

This year nobody stayed indoors to wait their turn. Everyone had heard about the new boards. The whole row was out in the lane in the cold, craning to look, and when the officials stopped at the dyer's house, two doors above Yoichi's, and the clerk lifted the lid of the box, a murmur ran down the lane, as it does at a festival when the first float comes around the corner.

The thing he took out and laid on the mat was not a board at all. It was a plaque of brass, a little longer than a man's hand from wrist to fingertip, with a raised rim all around like the edge of a tray. The low winter sun came in through the open door and lay across it, and it shone, gold, like nothing anyone in Kōya-machi had ever seen lying on a dirt floor. In the middle of it, standing up out of the metal so that it threw a small shadow, was the figure of a man on a cross.

His arms were stretched wide along the crossbeam, and his head was bowed a little to one side, and his feet were nailed together, one over the other, at the foot of the cross. A cloth was knotted around his hips, its loose end lifting as if in a wind. Above his head was a little board with letters on it in the foreign script. And below him, very small and fine, there was a city with walls and towers and domed roofs, a city in a far country, outside whose walls they had killed him.

Yoichi was standing in the lane with the others, at the dyer's threshold. He could see it from where he stood. The sun was full on it.

He could see the face.

It was not like the copper on the old board, worn to a shape. It was new. It was sharp. Every line of it was as clear as the day it came out of Hagiwara Yūsa's mold. The closed eyes. The thin cheeks. The mouth a little open, as if at the very end he had been about to say something, and had not had the breath.

The man who swept the magistrate's yard had been right. He looked so real, and so sad, that you were afraid to look at him.

✦ ✦ ✦

The dyer's family stepped, all six of them, the old dyer leaning on his son, the youngest girl hopping across on one foot as if it were a game. Someone in the lane laughed nervously, the way people do at funerals, and one of the headmen said something sharp, and the laughing stopped. Their bare feet came down one after another, on the cross, on the outstretched arms, on the face. Then the door slid shut, and the officials came on down the lane to Osen's.

Yoichi's heart was beating very slowly and very hard, like the mallets in the lane.

Step, Tomasu. Kichizaemon's voice. *Step, and come home and pray. That is your work.* He knew it was true. He had promised. He had stepped eleven times, he could step twelve. It was cold brass, that was all. The same as the copper, only newer. He would put his foot on it and press his seal in the book and bow to Shōzaemon, and close the door and say the *Konchirisan*, and in the spring he would go out to Urakami and help Matakichi plant the rice. Everyone would be safe. That was the right thing. He knew it was the right thing.

Osen stepped quickly, with her eyes on the ground, as most of them did, and turned at once to lift the child. But Okiku had seen

the brass shining on the floor of her own house and wanted to look at it. She wriggled down out of her mother's arms and squatted beside the mat in her padded jacket and peered at the little brass man, very close, the way she had stood in Yoichi's doorway and peered at his sandal strap.

"Who is he?" she said, loudly, in her clear high child's voice.

The lane went quiet. The clerk frowned.

"A bad foreign god," Osen whispered, scarlet, grabbing at her. "Hurry up. Step on him."

Okiku looked at the face for a moment longer.

"He's sad," she said.

And then, because her mother was pulling at her arm, and because she was four years old and did not understand anything, she stood up and put her small bare foot on the face of Christ, carefully, the way a child steps on a stone in a stream, and hopped off, and ran to the doorway to watch Shōzaemon write her name.

Yoichi stood in the lane looking at the brass.

He would never be able to say, afterward, what happened in him then. There was nothing to see. He did not hear a voice. He did not decide anything, any more than a man decides to catch his breath when he comes up out of deep water. He only knew, standing there in the lane with the wind in his face, that the old man had been right, that it was not a thing that was done with words or with reasons. It was done with feet. And that his feet were not going to move.

It was not courage. He was more afraid than he had ever been in his life. It was not anger at those who stepped, at Osen or the dyer or the child or Kichizaemon or his own grandmother; he had never felt

so tender toward any of them. It was not even, exactly, faith, if faith was something a man held in his head.

It was only this: that he had seen a face. A tired face, a man's face, with its mouth a little open as if he had been about to say something. And he knew whose face it was, and he loved it, and he could not.

He has already been stepped on. For me.

Peter, do you love me?

The clerk carried the brass next door and bent and laid it on the mat inside Yoichi's own doorway, on the earthen floor where he had sat three nights before mending his sandal and telling a child about a man who went out into the hills to look for a sheep.

"Yoichi." It was Shōzaemon, at the threshold, with the register open and his brush in his hand. "Yoichi. It's your turn."

Yoichi walked in through his own door and stopped at the edge of the mat.

Behind him the lane was very quiet. He could hear the wind snapping the paper of the New Year decorations on the gateposts, and somewhere a long way off, the mallets still going in another ward, pounding rice. He could feel everyone looking at him through the open door. He could feel the headmen straighten.

"Yoichi," said Shōzaemon again. His voice had changed. "Go on."

Yoichi looked down at the brass. The sun was on it. The little city with its towers. The arms spread out wide, as if to take in the whole of Kōya-machi, the whole of Nagasaki, every foot that had ever come down on him. There were faint marks on the face already, from the dyer's family and from Osen and from Okiku's small foot.

Dust. A smear of mud. The face did not mind them. It was not looking at them. Its eyes were closed.

"I can't," Yoichi said.

He had not known he was going to say it out loud. His voice sounded very strange to him, quite calm and ordinary, as if he were telling Shōzaemon he could not come to dinner.

The ward elder stepped over the threshold. He was trembling. He came across the floor very quickly for so heavy a man, and took Yoichi by the arm and put his mouth close to his ear.

"Are you sick?" he whispered. "Are you drunk? For the love of all the Buddhas, Yoichi, think what you're doing. Just put your foot on it. Your heel. Anywhere. Touch the edge, and I'll write that you stepped. Nobody will look. I'll swear to it. Do it now, quickly, before..."

Yoichi turned and looked at him. The old man's eyes were wet. He had known him all his life.

"Thank you, Shōzaemon-sama," Yoichi said, very low. "But they would know you lied. And then they would hang you next to me."

"Yoichi..."

"I'm sorry," said Yoichi. "I'm sorry for the trouble. Truly I am."

He knelt down on the cold earthen floor at the edge of the straw mat, with the whole lane watching through the open door. He put his hands together. And then he bent forward, slowly, the way you bow before an altar, or before your father, and laid his forehead on the cold brass at the foot of the cross, beside the nailed feet.

He heard Osen cry out behind him. He heard the dyer's wife say *Oh, no, no.* He heard the iron-bound box clatter to the floor as the clerk shoved past Shōzaemon. He heard nothing else, for a moment, but his own breathing, and the wind, and the beating of his heart.

The brass was very cold against his forehead. It smelled of metal and dust.

My Lord, he thought, *and my God.*

Then hands took hold of his shoulders and dragged him up.

穴

VII

The Pit

The first month, Kanbun 10 (1670)

THEY PUT HIM IN THE EAST CELLS AT SAKURAMACHI, IN the long cell with the lattice of square-cut timber, where he had carried water to Kyūemon twelve years before. Sukezō brought the bucket that evening. He stood outside the lattice with the ladle in his hand and would not look at Yoichi, and his face was blotched and swollen as if he had been crying, or trying not to.

"Why?" he said, at last, in a whisper. "Why? You never said. You never said anything."

Yoichi took the ladle through the bars and drank. The water was very cold. When he had finished, he gave it back, and bowed his head over it a little.

"Thank you," he said. "A blessing on the one who gave it."

The boy stared at him. Then he went away down the passage very fast, and did not come back that night.

✦ ✦ ✦

The magistrate's examiners were patient men. They had been doing this work for a long time, and they had learned that a man who would not step was a door, and the important thing was not the man but the room behind the door. They did not ask Yoichi, at first, to step. They asked him who had taught him.

He told them the truth. He had decided, kneeling in the straw the first night, that he would tell them nothing that was not true, and nothing that could harm a living soul.

"An old man from Kōri," he said. "A cultivator. His name was Kyūemon. He was in the east cells at Sakuramachi in the third and fourth years of Meireki. I carried his water. He went to Nishizaka with the others in the seventh month."

The examiners looked at each other. One of them sent a clerk for the old registers. The clerk came back with them and found the name, and the date, and the word *executed*, in a neat hand, and showed it to the senior examiner, who grunted.

"Who else?"

"My grandmother. Toku of Kōya-machi. She was baptized as a child, before the edicts. She had fallen. She remembered the prayers. She taught them to me."

"Where is she?"

"Buried at Daion-ji. Six years ago."

"Who else?"

Yoichi said nothing.

"Who else? A turnkey does not become a Christian in a prison cell, from an old farmer, in a few months. A turnkey does not learn the prayers from an old woman who forgot them thirty years before.

Somebody has been teaching you since. Somebody has been giving you books. Who? Where do you go, on your rest days?"

Yoichi was silent.

"Your neighbors say you go out of the city. North. Where?"

He said nothing.

They asked him again the next day. And the next. The asking grew harder each time. On the third day they began to use the water. The fourth day he did not remember afterward, except as a long darkness in which someone kept asking him the same question over and over, very calmly, *Who? Where?*, and he kept answering in his mind, *Ten ni mashimasu warera ga on-oya*, Our Father, who art in heaven, over and over, because it was the only thing he could hold onto, and the words came between him and the question like a wall.

He did not give them a name. He did not know, afterward, how he had not. He had told Kichizaemon *never*, and the old man had been right: every man said *never*. He had not been brave. He had wept, and cried out, and once he had heard himself begging them to stop, in a voice that was not his own. But each time the question came, he found there was nothing in his mouth to answer it with. Only *Our Father*. Only *Zezus, Maria*. As if someone had taken the names out of him and kept them safe, somewhere he could not reach.

After ten days, the senior examiner sat down across from him on the floor of the room at the magistrate's office, and looked at him for a long time, with something that was almost pity.

"You're a fool," he said. "You know that. You've done nothing. You have no priest to protect. Your teachers are dead. No one will ever know what you did. If you step, now, today, you can go home. You can have your post back, even. I'll see to it."

Yoichi looked at him through one eye. The other was swollen shut.

"Thank you," he said. "I'm sorry. I can't."

The examiner sighed and stood up.

"Then you'll go into the pit," he said.

✦ ✦ ✦

They took him up to Nishizaka in a cart, on a morning of thin cold rain, along the road by the harbor where he had walked beside Kyūemon. He could not walk himself anymore. He lay on his back in the cart and watched the gray sky go by overhead, and the gulls turning in it, and thought how strange it was that he had walked this road so many times and never once seen the sky above it.

The pit was at the top of the hill. It was a hole in the ground, deep as a well and narrow as a man's shoulders, and in the bottom of it, they told him, was filth. Over the top they had built a frame of timber, with two boards that closed together like a pair of hands, with a hole between them.

They bound his body tightly with rope, from his chest to his knees, so that the blood would not all rush to his head at once, and he would not die too soon. They made a small cut at his temple, so the blood would drip out slowly from there. Then they tied his feet together and hung him by them from the frame, head down into the dark, and closed the boards around his waist, so that his legs were up in the cold rain and air, and the rest of him was below, in the pit.

They left his right hand free. That was the custom. If he wished to give up his faith, he had only to reach up out of the dark and

make a sign, and they would pull him out, and give him water, and send for a doctor.

It is not possible to describe the pit. Those few who came out of it alive seldom spoke of it. The darkness and the stench and the pressure in the head, as if the skull were filling up with sand. The sound of your own blood, dripping, slowly, a drop at a time, on to the filth below. The way time comes apart, so that you cannot tell whether you have been there an hour or a day. The voices that are not there. The thirst.

He prayed. When he could not pray, he said the names. When he could not say the names, he thought them. *Zezus. Maria.* When he could not think them, he hung in the dark, and that was all, and someone else held them for him.

Once, in a clear moment, he remembered Peter, who had denied his Lord three times by a fire in a courtyard, and had been crucified at the end, they said, upside down. *One yes for every no.* He had said no eleven times. He thought that if he had laughed, it would have hurt very much. So he only said, inside himself, *Yes*, and then again, *yes*, and kept on, slowly, counting, until he lost count.

Sometimes he thought he saw Kyūemon. Sometimes it was his grandmother, sitting at her loom with the shuttle in her hand, looking at him over her shoulder. Once, very clearly, it was Okiku, squatting at the edge of the straw mat in her padded jacket and looking at the little brass man with her finger in her mouth. *He's sad.* He wanted to tell her: *No, not anymore. Not now.* But she had gone.

He prayed for her. For Osen. For the dyer's family, every one, by name. For Shōzaemon, who had wept, and offered to lie for him. For Kichizaemon and Matakichi and old Kame and the whole valley of Urakami, without saying its name even in his head, in case the

walls of the pit could hear. For Gonroku and his bad back. For the examiners, and the men who had used the water, and the men who had bound him with the ropes and closed the boards. *As we forgive those who trespass against us.* His grandmother had said that was the line it would take his whole life to learn. He thought perhaps he had very nearly learned it.

He did not raise his hand.

✦ ✦ ✦

On the third night, it was Sukezō who had the watch.

Yoichi knew it was the boy because of the cough, a nervous young man's cough in the cold, and because of the way he paced. Back and forth by the frame. Back and forth. Late, when the other guard had gone down the hill to sleep in the hut, the pacing stopped, and the boy crouched down by the boards, close, and spoke into the gap.

"Yoichi-san." A whisper. "Yoichi-san. Are you alive?"

It took a long time to find a voice. "Yes."

"Raise your hand." The boy's voice was shaking. "Please. Please. They told me. Just raise your hand, and I'll call them, and they'll pull you up. I'll run. I'll go right now. Please."

"No."

"Why? Why?" The boy was weeping now, openly. "I don't understand. You never even told anybody. Nobody knew. You could have just stepped and nobody would ever have known. Why?"

Yoichi hung in the dark and thought about it. It seemed very important to get the answer right. It was perhaps the most important thing he would ever say, and he had very little breath left to say it.

"He was stepped on first," he said at last. "For me. And for you, Sukezō. For you too."

The boy said nothing. Yoichi could hear him breathing.

"Sukezō."

"Yes."

"Water."

There was a long silence. Then a sound of movement, and of the boy's feet going away across the hilltop, and coming back. Something touched Yoichi's hand, his free hand, hanging down in the dark beside his face. A cloth. Soaked in cold rainwater from the barrel by the hut. The boy had lowered it on a cord between the boards. Yoichi's fingers closed on it. He could just get it to his mouth.

It was the best thing he had ever tasted in his life.

"Thank you," he said, when he could. "A blessing on the one who gave it."

He heard the boy begin to cry again, quietly.

"Listen, Sukezō. Tonight. When you lie down. Say this. *If you are there, let me know you.* That's all. It's a prayer he has never once refused."

"*If you are there,*" the boy whispered, "*let me know you.*"

"Yes."

They said nothing else for a long time. The rain had stopped. Through the gap between the boards, if he turned his head a little, Yoichi could see a thin line of sky, and in it, one star.

Toward morning, the boy heard him speak again, so softly that he had to put his ear against the boards. It was not to him. It was not in any language Sukezō knew. Two words, and then, after a

while, the same two again, very softly, as if someone had called him by his name from the next room and he was answering.

Then there was nothing.

✦ ✦ ✦

When the officials came up the hill in the morning they hauled him out of the pit and laid him on the wet grass, and the doctor bent over him and stood up again and shook his head. They wrote in the register: *Yoichi, turnkey, of Kōya-machi. Did not recant. Died in the pit on the fourth day.*

They burned his body on the hill, as was the custom, and took the ashes out in a boat beyond the harbor mouth and scattered them on the sea, so that no one could gather them up.

The ward elder, Shōzaemon, was reprimanded for laxity in the oversight of his ward and fined a sum of silver that he could ill afford. The officials came back to Kōya-machi, and every household stepped again, before them, one by one, on the brass. Every one of them stepped. Osen held Okiku very tightly in her arms, and set her down on the face, and lifted her off it, and did not let her look.

The examiners sent inquiries out along the north road, and through the villages beyond the city, but they had nothing to go on but a direction and the shrugs of Yoichi's neighbors, and after a while the matter was closed. No one came to Urakami. In the spring, Matakichi planted the rice.

It was Sukezō who was given Yoichi's padded winter coat to burn, with the rest of his things. He took it behind the guardroom to the fire. He found the paper inside the lining when he felt something stiff under his hand, and he unfolded it, and saw the close careful brushwork, and read the first line, and folded it up again very

quickly, with his heart pounding, and put it inside his own coat. And then he burned the rest.

He could hardly read. He was a ward runner's son, and had had only two winters at the temple school. It took him half a year to read it all, by himself, alone, at night, a few characters at a time.

O Deus, who are infinitely good, and worthy to be loved above all things.

七代

VIII

Seven Generations

Genji 2 (1865)

THE CHURCH STOOD ON THE HILLSIDE ABOVE THE foreigners' settlement at Ōura, new and white, with a tower and pointed windows of colored glass and a cross on the top that could be seen from the harbor. The people of Nagasaki called it the French Temple. They went in crowds to stare at it, as they went to stare at the steamships and the foreigners' houses with their glass windows and their iron balconies. The French priest who kept it let them in and showed them around, smiling, and said little. He was not permitted to preach to Japanese. The edicts were still posted on the notice boards at every crossroads, as they had been for two hundred and fifty years: *The evil sect of the Kirishitan is strictly forbidden.*

On a cool, bright afternoon at the beginning of spring, in the second month of the second year of Genji, the seventeenth of March by the foreigners' calendar, a group of men and women from Urakami came over the hill and stood outside the gate.

There were fifteen of them, perhaps. Farmers. You could tell by their hands, and by the way they stood. They looked like any other party of country people come to gawk at the French Temple. They had come in ones and twos, by different paths, and met at the gate as if by chance.

Among them was a woman of fifty named Mitsu, from Nakano. She had a thin, careful face and a farmer's thick wrists, and she was so frightened she could feel her knees shaking under her kimono.

The priest was working in the garden. He saw them at the gate, and came and unlocked it, and let them in, and led them up the steps into the church, as he had done for so many others.

It was dim inside, after the bright day. It smelled of new wood and candle wax and something else, something sweet, that Mitsu did not know. The windows glowed. At the far end there was an altar with candles on it, and above the altar, a cross.

The priest walked up to the altar and knelt down before it, with his back to them, and bowed his head, and prayed. They stood in a little cluster at the back and watched him. No one spoke. Mitsu found that she was gripping the sleeve of the woman next to her, a woman from another hamlet of the valley, Yuri, whose baptismal name was Isabelina. Yuri's arm was trembling too.

Then Yuri let go of her, and walked up the aisle, and knelt down beside the foreign priest. Mitsu and another woman followed her. Mitsu did not decide to. Her feet simply moved.

Yuri put her hand on her heart. Her voice, when it came, was very low.

"The heart of all of us here," she said, "is the same as your heart."

The priest turned and looked at her. Mitsu saw his face. He was young, with a brown beard, and his face had gone completely still, the way a man's face goes still when he hears a sound he has been listening for all his life and is afraid he imagined.

"Truly?" he said, in his strange, careful Japanese. "Where do you come from?"

"From Urakami," said Yuri. "In Urakami, almost everyone has the same heart as ours." And then, all at once, in a rush, like a child: "Santa Maria. Where is the image of Santa Maria?"

The priest stood up. He was shaking. He led them to the side of the church, where there was a statue on a pedestal, painted, of a young woman in a blue mantle, holding a child.

The women knelt in front of it.

"Yes," Yuri said. "Yes, it is Santa Maria. Look at the honored child Zezus, in her arms."

Mitsu knelt beside her and looked up at the face of the mother and the face of the child. She had never seen them before, not in all her life. She had only ever heard them described. She found that she was weeping, and could not stop, and did not try.

Later, the others told the priest about their calendar, and the feasts. They told him that they kept the feast of the Lord's birth on the twenty-fifth day of the month of frost. They told him that they were keeping now the season of sorrow before the Lord's death, and asked him whether he was keeping it too. When he said that he was, that this was the season the padres called Lent, they looked at each other and smiled, and could not stop smiling. They had kept the calendar for seven generations, and it had not lost count.

Mitsu said nothing. She knelt in front of Santa Maria with her hands pressed together, and under them, inside her kimono against

her skin, folded small and wrapped in oiled paper, she felt the edges of the thing she had brought.

✦ ✦ ✦

It was not the paper Sukezō had found in the lining of a dead man's coat. That had crumbled to nothing long ago. It was a copy of a copy of a copy, written out again by each generation of her family when the one before began to fall apart. But it was the same words. Her grandfather had made her learn them by heart when she was a girl, as he had learned them from his father. *O Deus, who are infinitely good, and worthy to be loved above all things.*

And on the outside of the folded paper, in her own hand, as in her mother's and her grandfather's before her, there was a line that was not part of the prayer.

For Tomasu of the prison, who did not step. And for those of us who did.

That was all. Her family did not know much more than that about him. They knew that the first of them, the one who had found the paper, had been a turnkey at the old prison in Sakuramachi, and had come out to Urakami a few years after the matter of the brass, and had asked to be baptized, and had married a girl of Nakano and stayed. How he had found his way there, the family did not say. Perhaps it was not known. They knew that every New Year, on the day the officials came to Urakami with the brass, after they had stepped and come home and closed the shutters, they said the prayers for Tomasu, along with the prayers for their own dead. That was all. It had been enough.

She thought of the brass.

They did not bring it out anymore. They had stopped some years ago, after the foreign ships came and the treaties were signed. In the last years, before the end, she had heard people say that the faces were all worn away. That you could not see them anymore. That under the feet of nearly two hundred years, the brass had been rubbed as smooth as a pebble in a stream, just as old Kichizaemon in the story had said it would be, and where the face of the Lord had been there was nothing left but smooth, bright metal in the shape of a head, with no features at all.

She had stepped on it herself, every year of her life, from the time her mother first set her bare foot on it as a baby. She had not looked. None of them looked. She knew, now, kneeling on the floor of the French Temple in front of Santa Maria, what she would see if she ever did.

She would see that it was still a face. That it had never been anything else. That they had walked across it, all of them, the whole of Kyushu, for nearly two hundred years, the proud and the fearful, the faithful and the faithless, those who stepped and those who would not, those who believed and those who only did as they were told, and those who stepped with their hearts breaking and went home and prayed the *Konchirisan*. And under all of them, under every foot, he had lain there with his arms spread wide. He had never once pulled his face away. He had let them wear it down to nothing. He had let them do everything to him.

He was stepped on first. For me.

Mitsu bowed her head, there in the dim church, before the mother and the child.

✦ ✦ ✦

There would be one more persecution. Two years later the officials would come to Urakami in the night, and the arrests would begin again, and before it was over more than three thousand of the people of the valley would be sent away into exile in distant domains, and more than six hundred of them would die there. Mitsu would be one of those sent away. She would come home, and many would not.

But the edicts would come down from the notice boards at last, in the sixth year of Meiji. And the people of Urakami would build a church of their own on the hill above their valley, out of red brick, with their own hands, on the very ground where the village headman's office had once stood, where their parents and grandparents had been made to step on the brass every New Year. And there, as Bastian had promised, they would go to confession every week, and sing their songs aloud in the street, and no one would stop them.

But that was later. Now, on this afternoon at the beginning of spring, Mitsu knelt on the wooden floor in front of Santa Maria with her hands pressed against her heart, over the folded paper, and wept, and could not stop, and did not try. Someone had come to meet them. Someone had been waiting.

The ship had come.

They had kept it.

史実

A Historical Note

Yoichi, his grandmother, Kyūemon, Kichizaemon, Sukezō, Mitsu, and the people of Kōya-machi are invented. The world they live in is not.

The Christian century. Jesuit missionaries reached Japan in 1549. Within two generations there were perhaps 300,000 Japanese Christians, and Nagasaki, a fishing village given to the Jesuits by the Christian lord Ōmura Sumitada, had become an almost entirely Christian port city with churches, hospitals, and confraternities. The churches named in the story stood there: Todos os Santos, on the hill where the temple of Shuntoku-ji was later built, and Santo Domingo, whose site became the residence of the city's deputy governor (*daikan*). The *Dochirina Kirishitan*, a catechism in question-and-answer form, was printed in Japanese under the Jesuits; the edition of 1600 was printed in Nagasaki. The form of the Lord's Prayer that Yoichi's grandmother whispers follows its 1600 text.

The ban. Toyotomi Hideyoshi had twenty-six Christians crucified on the hill of Nishizaka in Nagasaki in 1597. The Tokugawa shogunate banned Christianity throughout Japan in 1614. Churches were demolished, missionaries expelled, and believers pressed to renounce their faith. In the decades that followed, every household had to register at a Buddhist temple, which certified that its members were not Christian. From about 1627, first at the urging of the Shimabara lord Matsukura Shigemasa and then under the Nagasaki magistrate Takenaka Shigeyoshi (in office 1629 to

1633), Christians were taken to the volcanic hot springs of Unzen and scalded with boiling water to make them apostatize. The pit (*ana-tsurushi*) was used from the early 1630s. The victim was bound tightly, hung upside down in a pit of filth, and given a small cut at the temple to slow death, with one hand left free to signal apostasy. Some lasted more than a week. The Jesuit provincial Cristóvão Ferreira renounced his faith in the pit in 1633. The Japanese Jesuit Julian Nakaura, who as a boy had travelled to Rome and met the Pope, died in it the same year. The last priest known to be at liberty in Japan, Konishi Mancio, was martyred in 1644. After that, Japanese Christians had no clergy for more than two hundred years.

E-fumi and the fumi-e. The ritual of *e-fumi*, "picture-treading," began in Nagasaki in 1629. Residents were made to step on a sacred image, and anyone who refused was arrested as a Christian. The first images were on paper. Later they were wooden boards set with devotional medals confiscated from Christians. In 1669 the Nagasaki magistrate Kōno Gon'emon Michisada had the caster Hagiwara Yūsa make twenty brass plaques, because the older images were wearing out. Nineteen survive; the twentieth is said to have been lost at sea in transport. By the late seventeenth century e-fumi was held in Nagasaki every year in the first days of the New Year. The ward elder (*otona*) and his headmen carried the image from house to house, laid it inside each doorway, and recorded each person's seal in a register. Every resident took part, children included. It also spread to most domains of Kyushu. Nagasaki abandoned the practice in the late 1850s, as the ports were opened to the Western powers. The brass plaque on the cover of this book belonged to the Nagasaki magistrate's office and is now in the Tokyo National Museum. Its face has been worn completely smooth.

The Kōri collapse. In 1657, a chance remark by a farmer named Hyōsaku from Kōri village in the domain of Ōmura led the Nagasaki magistrate Kurokawa Masanao to uncover a large community of hidden Christians around the village. This was the *Kōri kuzure*, the "Kōri collapse." Six hundred and eight people were arrested, including small children. Seventy-

eight died in custody, ninety-nine were released, twenty were imprisoned for life, and four hundred and eleven were sentenced to death. One hundred and thirty-one were beheaded at Hōkobaru in Ōmura in 1658. The rest were divided among other domains for execution: one hundred and twenty-three in Nagasaki, sixty-four in Hirado, fifty-six in Shimabara, and thirty-seven in Saga. Further mass arrests followed in Bungo (from 1660) and in the Nōbi region (from 1661). Kyūemon is imagined as one of the Kōri prisoners held in Nagasaki. The Sakuramachi prison, where the story places him, was the city's prison in this period.

The hidden Christians. Not everyone gave up the faith. In the villages around Nagasaki, above all in the Urakami valley just north of the city, on the Sotome coast, and later in the Gotō Islands, communities of *senpuku Kirishitan* ("Christians in hiding") kept their faith in secret for two hundred and fifty years. Outwardly they were Buddhist, and they stepped on the fumi-e when ordered. In secret they baptized their children through a lay baptizer (*mizukata*), kept the Church's feasts by a calendar held by a lay leader (*chōkata*), and handed down prayers (*orasho*) by memory, many of them in garbled Latin and Portuguese. After Buddhist funerals they said prayers to "undo" the sutras. They relied especially on *Konchirisan no ryaku* ("A Summary of Contrition"), a short guide to perfect contrition compiled by the Jesuits in 1603 and handed down in manuscript copies (it was first printed by the returning missionaries in 1869). It taught that a Christian who could not reach a priest could still receive God's forgiveness through sorrow for sin that came from love of God. In the story, Yoichi and the people of Urakami pray from it after treading on the image, as hidden communities are recorded to have done.

Their liturgical calendar was traditionally credited to a Japanese catechist called Bastian, who worked on the Sotome coast. His prophecy was remembered there for centuries: after seven generations, confessors would come again in a great black ship, Christians would be able to confess every week, and they would sing their hymns aloud in the street.

The discovery. On 17 March 1865, a few weeks after the new Ōura church was consecrated for the foreign community in Nagasaki, about fifteen people from Urakami came to it and approached the French missionary Bernard Petitjean as he prayed. A woman named Sugimoto Yuri, whose baptismal name was Isabelina, told him, "The heart of all of us here is the same as your heart," and asked where the image of Santa Maria was. The visitors told him that they kept Christmas and were then in the season of sorrow, which was Lent. The story's last chapter follows Petitjean's own account of that afternoon. Mitsu, who stands beside Yuri, is fictional. In the years that followed, tens of thousands of hidden Christians came forward across the region.

The persecution was not quite over. In 1867 the authorities began arresting the Christians of Urakami. From 1868, and above all in 1870, about 3,400 of them were sent into exile in distant domains, where more than six hundred died. This was the "fourth Urakami collapse." Under Western diplomatic pressure, the edict boards against Christianity were taken down in 1873, and the exiles came home. The returning Christians of Urakami later built a great brick church with their own hands on the site of the village headman's house, where they had once been made to step on the fumi-e. That church stood about five hundred meters from the hypocenter of the atomic bomb dropped on Nagasaki on 9 August 1945, and was destroyed. It has since been rebuilt.

Who stepped, and who did not. The real history of the hidden Christians is not mainly a story of people who refused to step. Most of them stepped, year after year, for two and a half centuries, so that the faith would survive for their children. They grieved over it and asked God's forgiveness. Without them there would have been no one left to walk into the Ōura church in 1865. Thousands of others, from the 1590s to the 1870s, refused and died. The Catholic Church has beatified or canonized several hundred of them by name, and the rest are known only to God. This story tries to honor both. Kyūemon's mercy toward the mother who steps, Kichizaemon's counsel, Yoichi's tenderness toward his neighbors, and the

line Mitsu's family writes on their prayer ("*For Tomasu of the prison, who did not step. And for those of us who did.*") are meant to say that the fumi-e did not divide the faithful from the faithless. On both sides of it there were people who loved the face beneath their feet.

Further reading. Shūsaku Endō's novel *Silence* (1966) is the best-known work of fiction about the fumi-e and the apostasy of priests under persecution. Nagayo Yoshirō's novella *Seidō no Kirisuto* (*The Bronze Christ*, 1923) imagines the caster of the brass fumi-e. This story is indebted to both and follows neither. For the history, see Stephen Turnbull, *The Kakure Kirishitan of Japan* (1998), and C. R. Boxer, *The Christian Century in Japan, 1549–1650* (1951). The UNESCO World Heritage nomination "Hidden Christian Sites in the Nagasaki Region" (inscribed 2018) and the materials of Japan's Agency for Cultural Affairs are also useful.

用語
Glossary

Ave Maria. The "Hail Mary." Hidden Christians kept it in Latin and Japanese forms, and it was among the first prayers children learned.

Bastian. A Japanese catechist of the Sotome coast, remembered in hidden-Christian tradition as the author of their church calendar and of a prophecy that the faith would be restored after seven generations.

Chōkata (帳方). "Keeper of the book." The lay leader of a hidden-Christian community, who kept the liturgical calendar and announced its feasts and fasts.

Credo. The Apostles' Creed.

Deus (デウス). God. Japanese Christians used the Latin word.

Dochirina Kirishitan (どちりなきりしたん). "Christian Doctrine." A catechism in question-and-answer form, printed by the Jesuit press in Japan in 1591–92 and 1600.

E-fumi (絵踏). "Picture-treading." The ritual of making people step on a sacred image to prove they were not Christian.

Fumi-e (踏絵). "Stepping-picture." The image used in e-fumi: first on paper, then a wooden board set with a medal, and from 1669 a cast-brass plaque.

Kan'ei, Meireki, Manji, Kanbun, Genji, Meiji. Japanese era names. The story runs from Meireki 3 (1657) to Kanbun 10 (1670), with a prologue memory of Kan'ei 6 (1629) and an epilogue in Genji 2 (1865).

Kirishitan (キリシタン). Christian, from the Portuguese *cristão*.

Konchirisan no ryaku (こんちりさんのりやく). "A Summary of Contrition," compiled by the Jesuits in 1603 and copied by hand for Christians who would have no priest to hear their confessions.

Kuzure (崩れ). "Collapse." The authorities' word for the exposure and mass arrest of a hidden-Christian community.

Mizukata (水方). "The one of the water." The lay baptizer of a hidden-Christian community.

Nishizaka (西坂). The hill above Nagasaki harbor where the Twenty-Six Martyrs were crucified in 1597 and many hundreds of Christians were executed afterward.

Orasho (おらしょ). Prayer, from the Latin *oratio*.

Otona / ward elder (乙名). The headman of a ward of Nagasaki, responsible for its registers and for conducting e-fumi.

Paraiso (パライソ). Paradise; heaven.

Pater Noster. The Lord's Prayer. In the *Dochirina*: *Ten ni mashimasu warera ga on-oya* (天にましますわれらが御親), "Our Father who art in heaven."

Tomasu (トマス). Thomas, the apostle who said, "Unless I see... I will not believe," and then, "My Lord and my God."

Zezus (ゼズス). Jesus, in the Portuguese-influenced pronunciation of the Kirishitan.



Fumi-e: Christ on the Cross. Cast brass, 17th century.
Used by the Nagasaki magistrate's office in the annual e-fumi.
Tokyo National Museum. Photograph © Tokyo National Museum, CC BY 4.0.

終